

O'LEVEL NOTES EDITING

SUBJECT

O'Level English 1184

EDITED BY

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I. FRAMEWORK (STAMP CARD)

A. Each letter in **STAMP CARD** represents one category of grammar error tested in the O-Level editing question.

B. Think of it like a bubble tea stamp card. Go through the letters one by one for every line, check each category, and stamp off errors as you find them until you collect all **8 corrections**.

S T A M P C A R D

"Stamp out all 8 errors — collect full marks!"

	Error Type	Quick Check Question
S	Subject-Verb Agreement	Does the verb agree with the subject in number?
T	Tense	Is the verb in the correct tense? Check time markers.
A	Articles	Is 'a', 'an', or 'the' used correctly? Based on sound, not spelling.
M	Match Pronouns	Does the pronoun match its antecedent in number, gender, and form?
P	Prepositions	Is the correct preposition used? Check fixed phrases and collocations.
C	Connectors	Is the linking word logically correct? 'Although' and 'but' cannot be used together.
A	Adjective / Adverb (Word Form)	Is it describing a noun (adjective) or a verb/adjective/adverb (adverb, usually ending in <i>-ly</i>)?
R	Right Number	Is the noun singular or plural? Does the quantifier match? <i>many/few</i> = countable; <i>much/little</i> = uncountable.
D	Degree of Comparison	Is the comparative or superlative used correctly? Never double up (<i>more taller</i> is always wrong).

C. How to Use STAMP CARD in the Exam

- Before you read a single word, write S-T-A-M-P-C-A-R-D in the margin.
- Read the entire passage once for meaning. Identify the tense and topic. Do not correct yet.
- For every numbered line, work through each STAMP CARD letter in order. Stop the moment you find the error — each line has **at most one**.
- Write your correction clearly. Tick error-free lines. Never leave any line blank.

D. Which letters to check first?

Check **T**, **S**, and **A** first on every line. These three account for the majority of errors. If you are stuck, run T, S, A again before moving to the remaining letters.

WHY THIS ORDER?

T, S, and A errors appear in almost every exam passage because they involve the most common grammar rules in English: tense consistency, agreement, and word class. Starting with these three means you will catch the majority of errors efficiently before spending time on the less frequent categories. Think of T-S-A as your first-pass filter.

II. ERROR TYPES IN DETAIL (STAMP CARD)

Each error type is explained with the full grammar rule, all known sub-patterns, worked examples, and annotated thought-process boxes that explain how an expert reader identifies and corrects each error.

2.1 Tense Errors [STAMP CARD: T]

- The tense of every verb must match the time frame the passage is set in.
- Narrative and recount passages use the **past tense**. Informative and factual passages use the **present tense**.
- Your first read of the passage (before editing) exists to establish the tense.

How to identify the passage tense — time markers

Technique: Look for time markers in the opening lines. These signal the tense before you check any verb.

Time Marker	Signals	Expected Tense
yesterday, last year, in 2010, once, at that time, in the past	Past events — completed	Past Simple throughout
every day, now, currently, generally, always, nowadays	Present facts or habits	Present Simple throughout
by 2030, in the future, next year, soon, eventually	Predictions or future states	<i>will</i> + base verb

The twelve English tenses

Technique: Know the form of all twelve tenses. The editing question most commonly uses Past Simple, Present Simple, and Present Perfect, but all are possible.

Present Tenses			
Tense	Form	When to Use	Example
Present Simple	verb / verb+s	Habits, routines, general truths, factual passages	She walks.
Present Continuous	am/is/are + <i>-ing</i>	Action happening right now	She is walking.
Present Perfect	have/has + p.p.	Past action with current relevance	She has walked.
Pres. Perfect Cont.	have/has + been + <i>-ing</i>	Ongoing action from past until now	She has been walking.
Past Tenses			
Tense	Form	When to Use	Example
Past Simple	verb+ed / irreg.	Completed action; narrative passages	She walked.
Past Continuous	was/were + <i>-ing</i>	Ongoing past action; background to event	She was walking.
Past Perfect	had + p.p.	Earlier of two past events	She had walked.
Past Perf. Cont.	had + been + <i>-ing</i>	Ongoing action before another past event	She had been walking.
Future Tenses			
Tense	Form	When to Use	Example
Future Simple	will + base	Prediction, promise, decision	She will walk.
Future Continuous	will + be + <i>-ing</i>	Action in progress at a future moment	She will be walking.
Future Perfect	will + have + p.p.	Completed before a future point	She will have walked.
Future Perf. Cont.	will + have + been + <i>-ing</i>	Ongoing up to a future point	She will have been walking.

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong tense in a passage

Technique: Establish the passage tense in your first read, then flag any verb that does not match.

Step 1: Read the full passage once. Identify the tense from time markers or context.

Step 2: For each numbered line, identify the main verb.

Step 3: Ask — does this verb match the passage tense?

Step 4: If not, correct it to the appropriate tense form.

Worked Example 1

Identify and correct the tense error: *She walk into the lab yesterday.*

Step 1: Time marker: *yesterday* — signals past tense.

Step 2: Main verb: *walk* — base form, not past tense.

Step 3: Correct to Past Simple: *walked*.

Answer: She *walked* into the lab yesterday.

Worked Example 2

Identify and correct the tense error: *I have seen that film last night.*

Step 1: Time marker: *last night* — a specific past time. Locks the event in the past.

Step 2: Present Perfect (*have seen*) cannot co-exist with a specific past time marker.

Step 3: Replace Present Perfect with Past Simple.

Answer: I *saw* that film last night.

Worked Example 3

Identify and correct the tense error: *The problem is compounding.* (passage describes a state)

Step 1: Structure: *is* + verb form. Ask — is the subject doing an action, or in a condition?

Step 2: The problem is described as being in a worsened state — not actively doing anything.

Step 3: Present participle (*compounding*) = ongoing action. Past participle (*compounded*) = state. Use past participle.

Answer: The problem is *compounded*.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Present vs Past Participle After 'To Be'

When you see *is/was/are/were* followed by a verb form, ask: is the subject **doing something**, or **in a condition**?

- **Doing something** → Present participle (*-ing*): "*The window is breaking.*" (right now, actively)
- **In a condition** → Past participle (*-ed/irregular*): "*The window is broken.*" (a state)

In the passage, *the problem is compounding* implies the problem is actively compounding something. That is not the intended meaning. The problem has been made worse — it exists in a worsened state. Therefore: *compounded*.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Present Perfect vs Past Simple

The Present Perfect (*have/has* + p.p.) links a past event to the present. The Past Simple treats the event as fully over.

- Use Present Perfect with: *already, yet, ever, never, just, since, for, recently*
- Use Past Simple with: *yesterday, last week, in 2010, at 3pm, on Monday* — any specific past time

If a specific past time marker and *have/has* appear together in one clause — that is a T error. A specific time marker locks the event in the past; the Present Perfect cannot be used.

Practice Questions — Tense Errors

Identify and correct the tense error in each sentence.

1. She walk to school every day.
2. He has visit the museum last week.
3. By the time she arrived, he left.
4. The bridge is building across the river. (Describe a completed state.)
5. They are enjoy the show right now.
6. Scientists studied the effects of pollution. (Passage is in present tense.)
7. She already finished her homework. (Use a signal word for Present Perfect.)
8. When the teacher entered, the students finished their test.
9. He has called her yesterday.
10. The results were announcing last Friday.

Quick Check — T

Ask these four questions on every line:

1. What tense is the passage in? (Established in your first read.)
2. Does this verb match that tense?
3. If the structure is *is/was + verb form* — is it present participle (action) or past participle (state)? Which is intended?
4. Are there sequence-of-tense markers (*before, by the time, after*) suggesting one past event preceded another? If so, the earlier action takes the Past Perfect.

2.2 Subject-Verb Agreement [STAMP CARD: S]

- A singular subject takes a singular verb. A plural subject takes a plural verb.
- The exam places extra words between the subject and the verb to make the wrong noun look like the subject. Your job is to strip those words out.

Question Type 1: Identify the true subject and match the verb

Technique: Isolate the subject by removing all intervening phrases. Then match the verb to what remains.

Step 1: Identify the main verb in the clause.

Step 2: Ask: who or what is doing / being this? That is the subject.

Step 3: Ignore everything between the subject and the verb (prepositional phrases, relative clauses, parenthetical phrases).

Step 4: Is the true subject singular or plural? Match the verb accordingly.

Worked Example 1

Correct: *The average age of caregivers are about 62.*

Step 1: Main verb: *are*.

Step 2: Cover *of caregivers*. Remaining subject: *the average age* — singular.

Step 3: Singular subject → singular verb.

Answer: The average age of caregivers *is* about 62.

Worked Example 2

Correct: *Each of the boys have a book.*

Step 1: Main verb: *have*.

Step 2: Subject: *Each* — an indefinite pronoun, always singular.

Step 3: Singular subject → singular verb.

Answer: Each of the boys *has* a book.

Worked Example 3

Correct: *Neither the teacher nor the students was present.*

Step 1: Compound subject with *nor* — apply the proximity rule.

Step 2: Subject closest to the verb: *students* — plural.

Step 3: Plural subject → plural verb.

Answer: Neither the teacher nor the students *were* present.

THOUGHT PROCESS — The Proximity Trap

The exam consistently places a plural noun immediately before the verb when the actual subject is singular. Your brain registers the noun closest to the verb — this is the trap.

The fix: Physically cover the words between *of* and the verb with your pen. Read the skeleton that remains. The subject becomes obvious.

“The average age [of caregivers] ____ about 62.” → Subject is *the average age* (singular) → *is*.

Five Tricky S Patterns

Pattern	Rule	Example
Collective nouns	group, team, committee, family — singular in formal writing	The committee <i>has</i> decided.
Indefinite pronouns	each, every, either, neither, no one, someone, everyone — always singular	Everyone <i>has</i> submitted.
‘A number of’ vs ‘The number of’	<i>A number of</i> = plural; <i>The number of</i> = singular	A number of students <i>were</i> late.
Or / nor — proximity rule	Verb agrees with subject closest to it	Neither he nor they <i>were</i> informed.
Relative clauses	Verb in clause agrees with noun the clause refers to	It is the students who <i>are</i> responsible.

Practice Questions — Subject-Verb Agreement

Identify and correct the subject-verb agreement error in each sentence.

1. The group of researchers have published their findings.
2. Each of the students have completed the task.
3. Neither the manager nor the staff members was informed.
4. A number of residents has complained about the noise.
5. The committee have decided to postpone the meeting.
6. The list of requirements have been updated.
7. Everyone in the two classes are expected to attend.
8. Neither John nor his friends was invited to the event.
9. The team of engineers are working on the problem.
10. The number of complaints are rising every month.

Quick Check — S

- (1) Strip out the words between *of* and the verb, or between commas and the verb. The remaining subject is clear.
- (2) Watch for: collective nouns (singular), indefinite pronouns (singular), *a number of* (plural), *the number of* (singular), and the proximity rule with *or/nor*.

2.3 Article Errors [STAMP CARD: A — Articles]

- The articles are *a*, *an*, and *the*. Each has a specific function.
- The key distinction for *a* vs *an* is the **sound** the following word begins with — not the letter.

Article	When to Use	Examples
<i>a</i>	Before singular countable nouns beginning with a consonant sound . First mention, non-specific.	a book, a university (/j/ sound), a one-way street (/w/ sound), a European (/j/ sound)
<i>an</i>	Before singular countable nouns beginning with a vowel sound . First mention, non-specific.	an apple, an hour (silent h), an honest man (silent h), an MBA (/em/ sound)
<i>the</i>	Before nouns that are specific, already mentioned, or uniquely identifiable. Before superlatives. Before unique nouns.	the book I mentioned, the tallest building, the sun, the Prime Minister
no article	Before plural countable nouns used generally. Before uncountable nouns generally. Before proper nouns.	Dogs are loyal. Water is essential. Singapore is small. She speaks French.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Sound, Not Spelling

Students default to checking the first *letter*. This is wrong. Check the first *sound*.

- *University* starts with U, but the first sound is like the letter 'y' (consonant). → **a university**.
- *Hour* starts with H, but H is silent. First sound is the vowel in 'owl'. → **an hour**.
- *MBA* — spoken as a letter name, M sounds like 'em' (starts with a vowel sound). → **an MBA**.
- *European* starts with E, but first sound is like the letter 'y' (consonant). → **a European**.

Rule: Say the word aloud in your head. Whatever sound comes first determines the article.

Worked Example 1

Correct: *She is a honest person.*

Step 1: Check the first sound of *honest*. The H is silent; first sound is a vowel (like the 'o' in 'hot').

Step 2: Vowel sound → use *an*.

Answer: She is *an* honest person.

Worked Example 2

Correct: *He is an honest and a hardworking employee.*

Step 1: Both adjectives (*honest* and *hardworking*) modify the same noun (*employee*).

Step 2: Only one article is needed before a pair of adjectives modifying the same noun.

Step 3: Remove the second article.

Answer: He is an honest and *hardworking* employee.

Worked Example 3

Correct: *She is interested in a environment.*

Step 1: *The environment* = the natural world — a specific, uniquely identifiable concept.

Step 2: Specific / unique → use *the*, not *a*.

Answer: She is interested in *the* environment.

Practice Questions — Article Errors

Identify and correct the article error in each sentence.

1. She waited for a hour before the doctor arrived.
2. He is an university student studying economics.
3. I saw a elephant at the zoo.
4. She is a honest and hardworking person.
5. He bought the some books from the library.
6. She is interested in a environment and sustainability.
7. It was an historic moment for the country.
8. She has a MBA from a prestigious university.
9. He gave an useful piece of advice.
10. The government introduced a new policy to protect a wildlife.

Quick Check — A (Articles)

- (1) Say the following word aloud. Vowel sound → *an*. Consonant sound → *a*.
- (2) Is the noun specific or already mentioned? → *the*. General statement with plural or uncountable noun? → no article.
- (3) Do two adjectives modify the same noun? Only one article is needed before the pair.

2.4 Pronoun Errors [STAMP CARD: M]

- A pronoun must agree with the noun it replaces (its antecedent) in number, gender, and person.
- It must also be in the correct grammatical form for its role: subject, object, possessive, or reflexive.

Full Pronoun Reference Table

Person	Subject	Object	Possessive	Reflexive
1st singular	I	me	my / mine	myself
2nd singular/plural	you	you	your / yours	yourself / yourselves
3rd singular (m)	he	him	his	himself
3rd singular (f)	she	her	her / hers	herself
3rd singular (n)	it	it	its	itself
1st plural	we	us	our / ours	ourselves
3rd plural	they	them	their / theirs	themselves

Question Type 1: Match pronoun to antecedent in number and gender

Technique: Find the noun the pronoun refers to. Check that the pronoun matches it in number (singular/plural) and gender.

Worked Example 1 — Number

Correct: *This patients are grateful for the subsidies.*

Step 1: Identify the noun: *patients* — plural.

Step 2: Demonstrative determiner: *this* is for singular nouns; *these* is for plural.

Answer: *These* patients are grateful for the subsidies.

Worked Example 2 — Subject / Object Form

Correct: *Me and my friend went to the library.*

Step 1: Pronoun is the subject of the sentence (performing the action). → subject form required.

Step 2: Remove *my friend*: “*Me went to the library*” → obviously wrong.

Step 3: Subject form = *I*. Convention: put yourself last.

Answer: My friend and *I* went to the library.

Worked Example 3 — Reflexive Misuse

Correct: *Please contact myself if you have questions.*

Step 1: Check: is the subject and object the same person? *You* are contacting *myself* — different people.

Step 2: Reflexive pronoun is not valid here. Use the simple object form.

Answer: Please contact *me* if you have questions.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Subject vs Object Form

The removal test: Remove the other person from the sentence and read it alone.

“The teacher gave the award to John and I.” → Remove John: *“gave the award to I”* → obviously wrong → use *me*.

The preposition rule: After any preposition (*to, for, with, between, from, at, by, of*) — always use the **object form**: *me, him, her, us, them*. Never *I, he, she, we, they* after a preposition.

Reflexive pronouns (*myself, himself, etc.*) are only valid when the subject and the object refer to the same person. *“He hurt himself”* = he hurt his own body. Valid. *“Contact myself”* = you are contacting yourself. Nonsensical. Invalid.

Practice Questions — Pronoun Errors

Identify and correct the pronoun error in each sentence.

1. This students are grateful for the help.
2. Him and her completed the task together.
3. The teacher gave the books to John and I.
4. Please send the report to myself by Friday.
5. Everyone must submit their own work by the deadline. (formal register)
6. Each student must complete their own project. (formal register)
7. The students submitted her work on time.
8. The boy lost his way; she was frightened.
9. Between you and I, the project is behind schedule.
10. Neither of the candidates have submitted their application.

Quick Check — M

- (1) Does the pronoun match its antecedent in number and gender?
- (2) Is the pronoun a subject (doing the action) or object (receiving it)? Use the correct form.
- (3) After any preposition → object form only. No exceptions.
- (4) Is *myself/himself/themselves* used? Ask: is subject and object the same person? If not → reflexive misuse.

2.5 Preposition Errors [STAMP CARD: P]

- A preposition error occurs when the wrong preposition is used with a verb, adjective, or noun.
- These are **fixed phrases** (collocations). There is no universal grammar rule. They must be memorised.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Why Prepositions Cannot Be Guessed

Consider *afflicted with*. Why *with* and not *by* or *from*? There is no logical grammar reason. The word *afflicted* simply collocates with *with* in English. Students who reason from logic will get these wrong.

Strategy: Every time you encounter a preposition error in practice, add it to a personal fixed-phrase list. Over time this becomes your most powerful revision tool for this category.

High-Frequency Fixed Preposition Phrases

interested in	responsible for	different from
depend on	consist of	result in
comply with	suffer from	capable of
apologise for	accuse of	associated with
afflicted with	aim at/for	interfere with
grateful for	proud of	dedicated to
participate in	believe in	insist on
good at	afraid of	familiar with
accustomed to	fond of	disappointed with

Worked Example 1

Correct: *She is good in Mathematics.*

Fixed phrase: *good at* (a subject or skill). Cannot substitute *in*.

Answer: She is good *at* Mathematics.

Worked Example 2

Correct: *He insisted at going alone.*

Fixed phrase: *insist on* + gerund (-ing form).

Answer: He insisted *on* going alone.

Worked Example 3

Correct: *She is afflicted through chronic illness.*

Fixed phrase: *afflicted with*. Non-negotiable — must be memorised.

Answer: She is afflicted *with* chronic illness.

Practice Questions — Preposition Errors

Fill in the blank with the correct preposition, or identify and correct the preposition error.

1. She is very capable ____ handling pressure under stress.
2. The students were grateful ____ the teacher's generous help.
3. The policy aims ____ reducing traffic congestion in the city.
4. He is very interested to learn more about marine biology.
5. She insisted at meeting the director in person.
6. They are very proud in their school's achievements.
7. The committee is responsible of ensuring fair practices.
8. She is very familiar in the procedures required.
9. He was disappointed about his examination results.
10. The new policy is associated to significant economic benefits.

Quick Check — P

If a line sounds wrong and you cannot identify the error under T, S, A, or M — look at any preposition. Ask: is this verb / adjective / noun typically paired with a different preposition? Build and maintain a personal fixed-phrase list throughout revision.

2.6 Connector / Conjunction Errors [STAMP CARD: C]

- A connector error occurs when the wrong linking word is used, or when two conflicting connectors appear together in one sentence.
- The connector must accurately reflect the **logical relationship** between the clauses it joins.

Logical Connector Types

Relationship	Connectors	Example
Contrast	but, however, yet, although, even though, despite, nevertheless	She studied hard, but she failed.
Cause	because, since, as, due to, owing to	She passed because she studied.
Result	so, therefore, thus, hence, consequently	She studied hard; therefore, she passed.
Addition	and, furthermore, moreover, in addition	She studied hard and revised her notes.
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as	She will pass if she studies.
Concession	although, even though, while, whereas	Although unpopular, it was necessary.

THOUGHT PROCESS — ‘Although’ + ‘But’ Cannot Co-exist

“Although he was tired, but he continued working.” — This is the most commonly tested C error. *Although* is a subordinating conjunction signalling concession. *But* is a coordinating conjunction also signalling contrast. Both signal the same logical relationship. English grammar only allows **one connector per logical relationship**.

Fix: Keep one, drop the other.

- *“Although he was tired, he continued working.”* *Correct.*
- *“He was tired, but he continued working.”* *Correct.*
- *“Although he was tired, but he continued working.”* *Wrong.*

Correlative Conjunction Pairs — Memorise These

Correct Pair	Common Error
not only ... but also	not only ... <i>and also</i>
neither ... nor	neither ... <i>or</i>
either ... or	either ... <i>nor</i>
both ... and	both ... <i>as well as</i>
whether ... or	whether ... <i>nor</i>
as ... as	as ... <i>than</i>
so ... that	so ... <i>which</i>

Worked Example 1

Correct: *Although he was tired, but he continued working.*

Two contrast signals in one sentence. Drop one.

Answer: Although he was tired, *he* continued working. (*but* removed)

Worked Example 2

Correct: *He is not only hardworking, and also creative.*

Correlative pair: *not only ... but also*. *And also* breaks the pair.

Answer: He is not only hardworking, *but also* creative.

Worked Example 3

Correct: *Despite he was ill, he came to school.*

Despite is a preposition. It takes a noun or gerund — not a clause with a subject and verb.

Answer: Despite *being* ill, he came to school.

Practice Questions — Connector Errors

Identify and correct the connector error in each sentence.

1. She studied hard, so she failed the exam.
2. Although the policy was popular, but it was poorly executed.
3. He is not only intelligent, and also diligent.
4. Neither John or Mary was invited to the event.
5. Despite he was late, he managed to complete the task.
6. She works hard, so she never achieves her targets.
7. Both the teacher as well as the students were present.
8. Whether he passes or not remains uncertain.
9. Although she was nervous, but she delivered an excellent speech.
10. She studies hard, and also she does not perform well in exams.

Quick Check — C

- (1) Does the connector match the logical relationship between the clauses?
- (2) Do you see *although*? Scan for *but*. If both are present, one must be removed.
- (3) Do you see one half of a correlative pair? (*not only, either, neither, both, whether, so, such*) Scan for the second half and verify it is correct.
- (4) Does *despite* appear? Check it is followed by a noun or gerund — not a full clause.

2.7 Word Form Errors — Adjective / Adverb [STAMP CARD: A]

- An adjective modifies a noun. An adverb modifies a verb, adjective, or another adverb.
- This is the **most frequently tested error type**. The error is almost always an adjective used where an adverb is needed.

Question Type 1: Identify the wrong word form

Technique: Find the describing word. Identify what it modifies. Then choose the correct word class.

Step 1: Find the word you are checking.

Step 2: Find what it is modifying or what role it plays in the sentence.

Step 3: Apply the rule:

- Modifies a noun → **adjective**
- Modifies a verb, adjective, or adverb → **adverb** (typically *-ly*)
- Is the subject or object → **noun**
- Expresses the action → **verb**

Step 4: Convert to the correct form.

Worked Example 1

Correct: *He spoke confidently in front of the class.*

Step 1: Word to check: *confident*.

Step 2: It modifies *spoke* — a verb. → Adverb form required.

Step 3: *confident* (adjective) → *confidently* (adverb).

Answer: He spoke *confidently* in front of the class.

Worked Example 2

Correct: *...unable to cope mentally and physical...*

Step 1: Word to check: *physical*.

Step 2: It modifies *cope* — a verb. → Adverb form required.

Step 3: Also check parallel structure: *mentally* (adverb) and *physical* (adjective) — the two must match.

Answer: ...unable to cope mentally and *physically*...

Worked Example 3

Correct: *Her improve was remarkable.*

Step 1: Word to check: *improve* (verb form). It is used as the subject.

Step 2: The subject of a sentence must be a noun.

Step 3: Convert to noun form: *improve* → *improvement*.

Answer: Her *improvement* was remarkable.

Word-Form Conversion Reference

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
care	care	careful / careless	carefully / carelessly
efficiency	—	efficient	efficiently
confidence	—	confident	confidently
significance	signify	significant	significantly
success	succeed	successful	successfully
necessity	necessitate	necessary	necessarily
fluency	—	fluent	fluently
frequency	—	frequent	frequently
health	—	healthy	healthily

Flat adverbs (no *-ly*):

- *hard* → work *hard* (NOT *hardly* = almost not at all — a different word)
- *fast* → run *fast* (NOT *fastly* — not a word)
- *late* → arrive *late* (NOT *lately* = recently — a different meaning)
- *high* → fly *high* (NOT *highly* = to a great degree — a different meaning)

Practice Questions — Word Form Errors

Identify and correct the word form error in each sentence.

1. She handled the situation very efficient.
2. The beauty girl won the national competition.
3. Her improve over the semester was remarkable.
4. He drives careful on the expressway every day.
5. The students were extreme disappointed with their results.
6. She sings beautiful on stage every performance.
7. He is a fluency English speaker who lives abroad.
8. They work hardly to meet every single deadline.
9. The team performed impressive under difficult conditions.
10. She is a success businesswoman who founded three companies.

Quick Check — A (Word Form)

- (1) Find the word. What is it modifying?
- (2) Before a noun or after a linking verb → adjective. Before/after a verb, adjective, or adverb → adverb.
- (3) Check parallel structures: both words joined by *and* must be the same word class (*mentally and physically*, not *mentally and physical*).

2.8 Singular / Plural & Determiner Errors [STAMP CARD: R]

- R covers two related error types: (1) a noun in the wrong number; (2) a determiner or quantifier that does not match its noun.
- Do **not** confuse R with S. S is about the verb not agreeing with the subject. R is about the noun itself being in the wrong form, or its determiner being wrong.

THOUGHT PROCESS — Countable vs Uncountable

A **countable noun** can be counted: *one book, two books*. An **uncountable noun** cannot be directly counted: *information, advice, water*.

The quantifiers and determiners that can be used with a noun depend entirely on this distinction:

- Countable plural: *many, few, several, a number of, these, those, both*
- Uncountable: *much, little, a great deal of, a piece of*

“*Many informations*” is wrong because *information* is uncountable — it has no plural form. Correct: *much information*.

Determiner–Noun Agreement Table

Determiner	Use with	Incorrect	Correct
many	Countable plural only	<i>many information</i>	<i>much information</i>
much	Uncountable only	<i>much students</i>	<i>many students</i>
few / a few	Countable plural	<i>few time</i>	<i>little time</i>
little / a little	Uncountable	<i>little students</i>	<i>few students</i>
fewer	Countable plural	<i>less books</i>	<i>fewer books</i>
less	Uncountable	<i>less students</i>	<i>fewer students</i>
this / that	Singular nouns only	<i>this patients</i>	<i>these patients</i>
these / those	Plural nouns only	<i>these information</i>	<i>this information</i>
every / each	Singular countable only	<i>every students</i>	<i>every student</i>
a number of	Countable (plural verb)	<i>A number of students was late.</i>	<i>A number of students were late.</i>
the number of	Countable (singular verb)	<i>The number of complaints are rising.</i>	<i>The number of complaints is rising.</i>

Uncountable Nouns — No Plural Form

information, advice, furniture, equipment, luggage, knowledge, news, progress, research, traffic, weather, work, music, money, food (general), education, evidence, homework, accommodation, behaviour, damage, harm, luck, scenery, travel.

Irregular Plurals to Memorise

datum → data criterion → criteria phenomenon → phenomena medium → media analysis → analyses
 basis → bases hypothesis → hypotheses curriculum → curricula

Practice Questions — Singular / Plural & Determiner Errors

Identify and correct the error in each sentence.

1. Many informations were shared at the conference yesterday.
2. Every students must submit their work by Monday morning.
3. The elderly are not just medical one.
4. She has less friends now than she did before.
5. There is many water left in the tank.
6. The criteria for selection has not been announced.
7. He ate much cookies after the examination.
8. These information is not available to the public.
9. The number of complaints are rising every single month.
10. A number of residents has complained about the excessive noise.

Quick Check — R

- (1) Is the noun countable or uncountable? Uncountable nouns have no plural form and take different quantifiers.
- (2) Does the determiner (*many/much, few/little, fewer/less, this/these*) match the noun?
- (3) Remember: R is about the noun form and its determiner. S is about the verb. Do not conflate them.

2.9 Comparative and Superlative Errors [STAMP CARD: D]

- D errors involve using the wrong degree of comparison, or forming it incorrectly by combining both the *-er/-est* suffix **and** the word *more/most* on the same adjective.
- Three degrees: **positive** (base form), **comparative** (comparing two), **superlative** (comparing three or more).

Formation Rules

Adjective Type	Positive	Comparative	Superlative	Note
One syllable	tall, old	taller, older	tallest, oldest	Double final consonant if short vowel + consonant: <i>big</i> → <i>bigger</i>
One syllable ending in -e	wide, safe	wider, safer	widest, safest	Add <i>-r/-st</i> only
Two syllables ending in -y	happy, easy	happier, easier	happiest, easiest	Change <i>-y</i> to <i>-i</i> , then add <i>-er/-est</i>
Two or more syllables	beautiful, careful	more beautiful	most beautiful	Never add <i>-er/-est</i>
Irregular	good, bad, far	better, worse, further	best, worst, furthest	Memorise. Never add <i>-er/-est</i> or <i>more/most</i>

THOUGHT PROCESS — How Many Things Are Being Compared?

Before choosing comparative or superlative, count the things being compared.

- Exactly two → **comparative** (*-er* or *more*): “*She is taller than her sister.*” (two people)
- Three or more → **superlative** (*-est* or *most*): “*She is the tallest in the class.*” (whole class)

The passage error *oldest* → *older*: the sentence compares the present to 2030 — two points in time. Two = comparative. → *older*, not *oldest*.

Double comparative / superlative: If you see both *more* and *-er* on the same adjective, or both *most* and *-est* — that is always an error. Examples: *more taller*, *more better*, *most safest*, *most fastest*.

Worked Example 1

Correct: *She is more taller than her sister.*

Double comparative: *more* and *-er* cannot both be used. *tall* is one syllable → use *-er* only.

Answer: She is *taller* than her sister.

Worked Example 2

Correct: *This is the most easiest question.*

Double superlative: *most* and *-est* cannot both be used. *easy* ends in *-y* → use *-iest* only.

Answer: This is the *easiest* question.

Worked Example 3

Correct: *He is the most intelligent of the two.*

Of the two signals exactly two items. Two items → comparative, not superlative.

Answer: He is the *more* intelligent of the two.

Practice Questions — Degree of Comparison

Identify and correct the degree of comparison error in each sentence.

1. Singapore is one of the most safest cities in the world.
2. She is more smarter than her classmates by a significant margin.
3. Of the two candidates, she is the most qualified for the role.
4. He is the most intelligent of the two finalists.
5. This method is more better than the previous one used.
6. 25 per cent of Singaporeans will be 65 years and oldest by 2030.
7. She is more happier than she was last year.
8. This is the most simplest explanation I can provide.
9. He runs more faster than anyone else on the team.
10. Of all the students, she scored the more highly on the test.

Quick Check — D

- (1) How many things are being compared? Two → comparative. Three or more → superlative.
- (2) Does the adjective take *-er/-est* or *more/most*? Apply the formation rules.
- (3) Do you see both *more/most* AND *-er/-est* on the same adjective? If yes — always an error. Remove one.
- (4) Irregular forms: *good/better/best*, *bad/worse/worst*, *far/further/furthest*. Never add *-er/-est* or *more/most* to these.

III. EXAMPLE (STAMP CARD)

Annotated Exam Passage — How to Apply the Framework

Instructions

Step 1. Write S-T-A-M-P-C-A-R-D in your margin before reading anything.

Step 2. Read the entire passage once for meaning. Identify the tense. Do not correct yet.

Step 3. Go back to line 1. For every numbered line, run through T, S, A first, then M, P, C, R, D.

Step 4. Write your correction clearly. Tick error-free lines. Never leave any line blank.

Your Attempt

Line	Passage	Your Answer
—	<i>Many caregivers of the elderly have their own health problems. The</i>	—
1	average age of caregivers are about 62. It is estimated that by 2030, about	
2	25 per cent of Singaporeans will be 65 years and oldest . The problems	
3	facing the elderly are not just medical one . Asset-rich but cash-poor,	
4	this patients are grateful for subsidies in healthcare, but what they fear	
5	most is to be afflicted through chronic diseases like dementia or stroke that	
6	leave them unable to cope mentally and physical , with conditions such as	
7	depression, and often accompanied by insomnia. A person with such	
8	ailments would need not only caregivers, and also the financial means to	
9	afford long-term treatment. When the caregivers, who are often spouses	
10	and close relatives, are also unwell, the problem is compounding . Thus,	
—	<i>Singapore needs to be prepared for the growing caregiving challenges.</i>	—

Answer Key — Annotated

Line	Correction	Change	STAMP	Annotated Explanation
—	Always correct.	—	—	Opening line; no numbered error.
1	are → is	S	S	Subject = <i>the average age</i> (singular). Strip out “of caregivers”. Singular subject needs singular verb.
2	oldest → older	D	D	Two points compared: now and 2030. Comparing two things → comparative (<i>-er</i>), not superlative.
3	one → ones	R	R	<i>Problems</i> (line 2) is plural. The pronoun substitute must match: <i>ones</i> , not <i>one</i> .
4	this → these	M	M	<i>Patients</i> is plural. <i>This</i> is for singular nouns; <i>these</i> is for plural nouns.
5	through → with	P	P	Fixed phrase: <i>afflicted with</i> . This preposition cannot be substituted — it must be memorised.
6	physical → physically	A	A	<i>Cope</i> is a verb. Words modifying verbs must be adverbs. Parallel structure with <i>mentally</i> also demands <i>-ly</i> .
7	No error	✓	✓	Tick this line. Do not force an error.
8	and → but	C	C	<i>Not only ... but also</i> is a fixed correlative pair. <i>And also</i> breaks the pair.
9	No error	✓	✓	Tick this line. Do not force an error.
10	compounding → compounded	T	T	Past participle <i>compounded</i> describes a state (the problem has been worsened). <i>Compounding</i> wrongly implies the problem is actively doing something.
—	Always correct.	—	—	Closing line; no numbered error.

ANNOTATION — How to Approach Error-Free Lines

Lines 7 and 9 are error-free. Two lines are **always** correct in every exam passage. When you have gone through all nine STAMP CARD letters on a line and found nothing, tick it immediately and move on.

Common mistake: students who expect every line to have an error will manufacture one on the correct lines. The exam specifically includes two correct lines to test whether you can recognise grammatically sound writing. If you have checked T, S, A, M, P, C, A, R, D and found nothing — the line is correct. Tick it.

EXAM TIPS

- 1 **Read for meaning first.** Step 2 of the procedure is not optional — the first read establishes the tense and topic, essential for T and C errors. Students who skip this step miss tense errors consistently.
- 2 **Check T, S, A first on every line.** These three account for the majority of errors. If you are stuck, return to these three before the others.
- 3 **Two lines are always correct.** Do not force an error. If STAMP CARD reveals nothing on a line, tick it and move on with confidence.
- 4 **Write corrections clearly.** Underline the error word in the passage. Write the correction on the answer line. Ambiguous markings lose marks even when the answer is right.
- 5 **Each numbered line has exactly one error.** Once you have found it, move to the next line immediately. Do not look for a second error on the same line.
- 6 **Memorise fixed preposition phrases (P).** These are not derivable from rules. Build and maintain a personal collocation list throughout your revision.
- 7 **For D errors, count the things being compared.** Two → comparative. Three or more → superlative. The number is always stated or implied in the sentence.
- 8 **Do not guess.** If you are stuck after checking all nine letters, mark the line and return after finishing the rest. A second pass under T, S, or A almost always reveals the answer.